

Hacker's laptop on auction

An online auction of the two laptops used to hack major corporations could get convicted cyber criminal Kevin Mitnick a tidy sum. In an effort to help finance a legal battle to regain his radio operator's license, the one-time hacker is auctioning the two Toshiba Satellite notebooks seized by law enforcement officers at eBay. "These were the laptops used to hack into companies and Shimomura's computers," Mitnick said. Tsutomu Shimomura, a senior fellow at the San Diego Supercomputer Center, helped track down Mitnick in 1995 after the hacker broke into the computer scientist's server the previous year.

The first laptop has a 486DX processor, 4 MB of RAM and a 200 MB hard drive with Windows 95 installed. Bidding on the machine reached \$9,200 (approx Rs 4,60,000) at the time of going to press. The second laptop sports an Intel 486SX processor and is marked with the dust used to lift fingerprints. This one has gone up to \$6,000 (approx Rs 3,00,000).

Both the laptops have been signed by Mitnick and Steve Wozniak, co-founder of Apple Computer and come with a copy of the FBI evidence form listing the make, model and serial numbers of the computers.

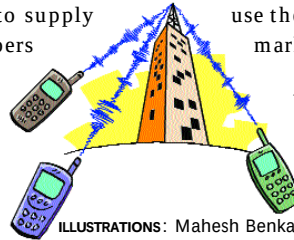
snapshot

Number of broadband connections in UK doubled since May 2002 to reach 1 million

Source: OfTel

Mobile P2P

A French company called Apeera reckons that mobile phones can act as nodes in vast peer-to-peer networks and aims to supply mobile subscribers with a personal network-based repository for content such as ring tones, games, etc. Apeera's technology lets users share this content and applications, boosting traffic on service provider networks and spurring adoption of the latest Java-based mobile phones.



Technologies such as GPRS and MMS can also be expected to get a boost, alongside attempts by operators to use the network to boost marketing initiatives. P2P networks bring with them a host of issues ranging from Digital Rights Management to mobile phone batteries and bandwidth to support such services. Then there's security issues, especially since mobile phones are beginning to hold more and more data.

Jackpot!

A new trend has people making loads of money playing games online. Mary Dion, a former accountant, has given up a



big job to become a professional online solitaire player at WorldWinner (www.worldwinner.com). Such sites call it 'skill-based gaming' to distinguish themselves from gambling sites. The games are simple and the business model straightforward. Customers pay a small entry fee, the site takes a cut from it, and the rest goes into a pot to be claimed by the top player.

tomorrow's technology

Spinning a new technology

Ohio State University has made inroads into a new field of technology called Spintronics, by dispensing with conventional chip-fabricating materials like silicon or gallium arsenide, for plastics. Temperatures within a computer reach as high as 50 degrees C, rendering this technology useless in the past. But a new polymer called vanadium tetracyanoethanide exhibits magnetic characteris-

tics even at high temperatures, thus jumping over this hurdle. Experiments have proved that a magnetic field can be used to polarise the spin of an electron. This is the first step towards enabling plastics to be used to store information. The advantage with Spintronics is that an electron retains its spin until it is changed by an external magnetic field. This implies that data is retained even after power is

quoteworthy

"Every new generation of consoles increases the capabilities of what we can do by five times. That's what we need to prepare for. We have to increase our skill-set."

Bruce McMillan, executive vice president of Electronic Arts' Worldwide Studios, which is responsible for several of this year's top games including *Medal of Honor*, sees the gaming industry growing to be more and more complex and even attracting some of Hollywood's best talent

"We have the lowest tariffs in the world and they can fall (further) by up to 20-30 per cent."

T.V. Ramachandran, director general of the Cellular Operators Association of India (COAI), on the growth of mobile services in India